

Divya Deshmukh

» BEST OF 2025
SEIZING HER MOMENT

Indian chess is a gift that keeps giving. In 2025, it delivered Divya Deshmukh, a teenager who forced her way into chess's highest tier by winning the FIDE Women's World Cup and, in the process, earning the Grandmaster title.

Entering the tournament in Batumi, Georgia, as the 15th seed, Divya was very much an outsider in a field of 107 players that included nearly every leading name except reigning world champion Ju Wenjun. But Divya navigated it with remarkable composure. She eliminated a succession of seasoned opponents to set up an all-Indian final against Koneru Humpy, but the warning signs were visible much earlier. In the fourth round, she knocked out China's Zhu Jiner, the second seed, before dispatching compatriot Harika Dronavalli in the quarterfinals.

Another giant fell in the next round. In the semifinals, Divya produced the result that truly shifted the narrative. Arriving without a single GM norm to her name, she defeated former world champion Tan Zhongyi 2.5–0.5, a scoreline that underlined both control and confidence.

The final against Humpy became a study in nerve. The two classical games ended in draws, pushing the contest into rapid tiebreaks. There, Divya seized her moment. In the second rapid game, Humpy faltered under mounting time pressure, and Divya converted calmly to secure a 2.5–1.5 victory.

The title brought a \$50,000 prize (approximately Rs. 43.35 lakh at the time) and a berth in the Women's Candidates, the eight-player event that decides the challenger for the world championship. More significantly, it confirmed Divya as India's 88th Grandmaster.

She was not done. Later in the year, at the FIDE Grand Swiss, Divya held reigning men's world champion Gukesh Dommaraju to a hard-fought draw, another marker of how quickly she was closing the gap at the very top.

The message was unmistakable. In modern chess, reputation offers no protection, and India's newest names are no longer content to wait their turn.

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